

The rise of China raises with urgency the question at the center of this book: will China try to delegitimize, overthrow, and replace the contemporary status quo order? This is the \$64,000 question of international relations and American grand strategy. Much rides on the answer, and not just for the prospects of direct Sino-American military conflict. As Thomas Christensen has argued, the central challenge associated with the rise of China is securing its cooperation in shouldering the burdens of global governance.¹ This requires getting Chinese leaders to buy into – or at least not reject – the status quo order, along with its rules, norms, and institutions. A China committed to protesting, undermining, and ultimately overthrowing and replacing the US-backed order will hardly be willing to help the United States manage problems like climate change or non-proliferation.

Many analysts – whom I refer to as “rejectionists” – believe that China is destined to challenge the order that the United States built after World War II and has maintained in some form since. For them, there are two options for Washington: become resigned to the demise of what Ikenberry calls the “liberal international order,” or prepare to contain the rise of China at great cost and the risk of serious conflict. For others – whom I label “integrationists” – options are less limited and the future is less gloomy: China can be persuaded that the status quo serves its interests and that it should become a defender – not a challenger – of the order’s rules, norms, and institutions.

Both rejectionists and integrationists err by ignoring the ways in which status ambitions may matter for China’s trajectory. Rejectionists go too far in arguing that a Chinese challenge to the status quo is inevitable. They base this claim on the records of the behavior of rising great powers from history, but my analysis in Chapters 3, 4, and 5 has shown that shifts toward radical revisionism were not structurally determined. In none of these cases was there a consensus about the wisdom of challenging the status quo order, and in each case the ultimate domination of the hardline perspective was to some

¹ Christensen (2015), p. 288.

degree a function of the nature of beliefs about the prospects of the rising power's status ambitions, which were in turn influenced by at least partially contingent factors like decisions made by domestic elites, the behavior of foreign actors, and the consequences of exogenous crises.

The integrationists, on the other hand, place too much faith in the idea that integration within the liberal order is in China's material self-interest. As a result they understate the difficulty of keeping China satisfied with the status quo. It is true that China profits from the open economic order that the United States underwrites, that it benefits by free-riding on the other public goods that American hegemony provides, and that its leaders understand how costly a war with the United States might be. Moderate leaders in Wilhelmine Germany, Imperial Japan, and Weimar Germany also appreciated the material benefits of *not* challenging the status quo orders within which their respective states rose to power. The material benefits of patience and integration were outweighed, in these cases, by a set of forces that have mostly been left out of analyses of China's trajectory: the social psychological and political consequences of beliefs about the compatibility of its status ambitions and the liberal order.

The purpose of this chapter is to demonstrate that these same forces are critical for understanding the future of Chinese foreign policy, and thus the future fate of the international order. China – like other rising states – has outstanding status ambitions. As is always the case when status is involved, these ambitions can only be satisfied if they are recognized. And this means that there is a possibility that influential Chinese observers may come to the conclusion that China's status ambitions have been unjustly obstructed and are incompatible with the US-backed order. Obstructed status ambitions might in turn lead to demands for policies that aim to protest, delegitimize, or overthrow elements of the status quo order, and these – if they are resonant and widespread enough – could influence Chinese foreign policy as they did in the German and Japanese cases from the first half of the twentieth century. In short, Western accommodation failure could produce forces that push China toward policies that reject and challenge the norms, rules, and institutions of the liberal international order.²

² This argument is similar in some ways to that made by other analysts of status in world politics. Larson and Shevchenko (2010; 2014a), for instance, have warned that China may adopt a geopolitically competitive form of status-seeking if it is persistently denied recognition (see also Wolf 2014 and Lee 2016). The problem with this claim is that China is *already* pursuing geopolitically competitive policies – like naval arms-racing – as part of a drive for status; and my analysis in the previous chapters suggests that geopolitical competition is neither the consequence of persistent status denial nor a necessarily destabilizing phenomenon. Rather, the danger raised by the prospect of status immobility is

My intention in making this argument is not to advocate that the United States accommodate Chinese status claims. Depending on what these are, accommodating them could be prohibitively costly. But the debate over whether or not to accommodate China should consider not only the costs of accommodation but also the costs of status denial, and these include the possibility of an adverse shift in China's orientation toward the status quo order. I return to the implications of my argument for US grand strategy in the concluding chapter.

This chapter proceeds in three parts. First, I describe the parameters of the "liberal international order," imagine what a Chinese shift toward rejecting and challenging the status quo order might look like, and briefly review the debate over the trajectory of Chinese foreign policy. Second, I establish that China has outstanding status ambitions and delineate the specific rights that China seeks to have recognized. This section also explores the question of why the West might fail to accommodate Beijing's claims. Third, I argue that accommodation failure could produce demands for policies that reject and challenge the status quo order (indeed, some Chinese elites already make these kinds of demands), and that these demands could influence foreign policy.

The Liberal Order and the Rise of China

The most obvious feature of the status quo order that confronts the rising China is American dominance. While China's economy has grown rapidly over the past two and a half decades and Chinese military capabilities have advanced, the United States maintains a marked advantage in economic productivity, innovation, and wealth, has by far the world's most powerful military, and remains the only state with global power projection capabilities. The United States also maintains status and influence advantages by virtue of its central positions in security, political, and economic institutions. These are the distributive elements of the status quo order, and Chinese foreign policy is currently oriented toward narrowing many of these gaps.³

One of the most important questions at the heart of the debate over the rise of China is whether China's advance along these distributive dimensions (increases in power, wealth, and influence) will lead to an effort to

that China will adopt a *radically revisionist* foreign policy orientation – that it will oppose and seek to undo the liberal order, instead of working to increase its standing (and influence) inside of it. This would not only hamper attempts at joint Sino-American global governance, but could also contribute to the rise of a less restrained belligerence in Chinese foreign policy.

³ On the robustness of American primacy, see Beckley (2011) and Brooks and Wohlforth (2015, 2016).

overthrow the normative elements of the status quo. These elements are the rules, norms, and institutions that constitute what Ikenberry has termed the “liberal international order.”⁴ In the years after World War II, the United States constructed a matrix of institutions whose purpose was to bind the United States to its allies and facilitate cooperation in the realms of security, politics, and economics. This order has persisted and evolved in the subsequent decades and consists now of formal and informal institutions, rules, and norms that constitute actors, help states to legitimate collective action, and regulate behavior. The liberal order is made up of formal institutions like the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the World Bank, and the International Monetary Fund; less formal institutions like the G7; norms and principles that relate legitimacy to standards of representation and human rights; and rules about, for instance, what kinds of states can legitimately possess nuclear weapons.

There are three key characteristics of the liberal international order. The first is that it is aimed at maintaining open and rule-based relations between states as a way of maximizing the benefits of economic interaction, minimizing the risk of major conflict, and reducing fears about American adventurism. The second is that – at least in the post-Cold War era – it is purportedly universal. The liberal international order is not geographically bounded, although the extent to which it is effective varies geographically. The third is that it is underwritten by American leadership: the United States provides a number of public goods in both the economic and security spheres from whose consumption other states benefit. For instance, the US dollar provides a global reserve currency, and American military power facilitates the free flow of resources and commerce.

China currently participates more or less fully in these institutions, but scholars disagree about whether its rise will mean the end of the liberal international order. China could buy into the order’s rules, norms, and institutions; its rise would accordingly change the order’s distributive dimension but strengthen and reinforce (while perhaps reforming) its normative foundation. There would still be Sino-American competition over power, influence, and status, but it would be constrained by a common commitment to the rules of the international security, economic, and political games. This was, by and large, the outcome of the Anglo-American power transition.

Alternatively, China could pursue policies aimed at weakening and overthrowing the liberal international order.⁵ This might entail open rule-

⁴ See Ikenberry (2011).

⁵ For discussions of what this might look like, see Ikenberry (2011), pp. 309–312 and Kupchan (2012), pp. 199–202.

breaking for the purpose of protesting or delegitimizing the rules and norms of the liberal order; the construction of parallel institutions and groupings of states aimed at opposing the Western order; and (as difficult as it might be to imagine) withdrawal from the institutions of the liberal order.⁶ An anti-liberal order foreign policy would be unlikely to involve an explicit commitment to military confrontation against the United States (especially given the dynamics of nuclear deterrence), but the pursuit of policies aimed at protest, delegitimation, and overthrow would contribute to Sino-American rivalry and could encourage leaders in Beijing to pursue other kinds of provocative policies (by lowering their costs and undercutting arguments against provocation). These might in turn raise the risk of Sino-American conflict.

The question of which of these paths China will choose is the subject of a lively debate among IR scholars. Rejectionists think there is little chance that China will integrate within the liberal international order. One strand of rejectionist reasoning emphasizes the supposed timeless dynamics of power transitions – rising states always seek more power, more influence, and more status, and they are not satisfied until they have achieved at least regional hegemony and reconstituted the international order on their own terms. This, for rejectionists, is the lesson of 1914.⁷ Another strand of rejectionist thought emphasizes civilizational or ideological differences between China and the founders of the liberal international order. As China grows more powerful, it will seek to create an order that reflects its civilizational values, domestic political ideology, and conception of its proper role in the world.⁸ This, for rejectionists, is one of the lessons of the fascist rising powers of interwar Europe and Asia.⁹

Integrationists, on the other hand, think that China can be persuaded that its interests lie in the persistence of the liberal international order. China benefits from the order's open, market-based economic system. The institutions of the liberal order are also, according to Ikenberry, open to accommodating the voice and ambitions of a rising power in a way that makes the Sino-American power transition unlike those from the first half of the twentieth century.¹⁰ Moreover, challenging the order would entail significant costs stemming from the provocation of Western powers. Chinese leaders understand this, which is why, since the time of Deng

⁶ See Pillsbury (2015), Chapter 9 for a full discussion.

⁷ See especially Mearsheimer (2010); Kagan (2005); see also Betts (1994); Friedberg (1994, 2000, 2011); Bernstein and Munro (1997).

⁸ See especially Pillsbury (2015), Chapter 1; Kupchan (2014a), p. 224; and Jacques (2009) p. 528.

⁹ Kupchan (2014b), p. 26.

¹⁰ Ikenberry (2011), pp. 343–345; see also Ikenberry and Wright (2008).

Xiaoping, they have sought to avoid giving the impression that China is a dissatisfied rising power.¹¹ Thus, if the United States can find ways to reassure China that the status quo order serves its interests (by, for instance, compromising on the status of Taiwan or taking greater account of the challenges China faces as a relatively poor, developing economy), China can be kept reasonably satisfied and perhaps even turned into a partner.¹²

Each of these perspectives captures an important piece of the picture. Rejectionists are right to emphasize the difficulty of accommodating a rising power within an order that it did not construct. Yet they neglect the role of politics and contingency in the stories of the twentieth-century revisionist rising powers, exaggerate the degree to which rising power necessarily drives deep dissatisfaction, and ignore the actual processes through which hardline preferences develop and influence decisionmaking. What this means is that the rejectionists are too pessimistic: a Chinese challenge to the liberal international order is no more inevitable from the perspective of 2017 than were the rise of Hitler or Japan's withdrawal from the League of Nations from the perspective of 1920.

The integrationists, though, are too optimistic. They are right to emphasize the material incentives that China faces to integrate within the liberal international order. But they miss other forces that might push Beijing toward radical revisionism. Each of the twentieth-century revisionists also had material incentives to behave moderately, and there were German and Japanese leaders that understood these incentives and wanted policy to reflect them. Yet in each case, moderate policies were defeated by hardline policies in part because of the social psychological and political consequences of status immobility – forces that are absent from optimistic integrationist analyses.¹³

Status Anxiety and the Rise of China

The remainder of this chapter contributes to the debate about the rise of China and the future of the liberal international order by exploring the implications of status immobility theory for the Sino-American power transition. Status immobility should not be understood as competing with the dynamics emphasized by extant rejectionist and integrationist

¹¹ Shambaugh and Xiao (2012), Kindle location 877. On China's "peaceful rise," see Zheng (2011), Chapter 6; and Guo (2006), Chapter 1.

¹² See, for instance, Glaser (2015), Goldstein (2015), Christensen (2015).

¹³ Glaser (2015), p. 64, for instance, acknowledges that non-security motives are outside the bounds of his analysis, which, as a result, misses a critical potential obstacle to a Sino-American "grand bargain."

accounts, but instead as highlighting a commonly ignored set of forces that need to be taken on board by both. In particular, I argue that demands that Chinese foreign policy reject and challenge the liberal international order – which are already common among some Chinese elites – might become more resonant and widespread if the United States fails to accommodate China's status ambitions and signals that these are incompatible with the status quo. This could, in turn, influence policy by pressuring the more moderate elites who currently control the government.

This section has two purposes. First, I argue that China has outstanding status ambitions, and that its foreign policy is currently aimed – in part – at satisfying them. Chinese elites and the public care deeply about international respect, and this concern influences the way China behaves externally. Chinese policy appears to be staking a claim to “great power” status, the satisfaction of which requires behavior by the United States that signals that China has two particular rights: to a sphere of influence in East Asia, and to freedom from external interference in its domestic affairs. In other words, China is currently pursuing distributive revisionism aimed at adjusting the distribution of status in the system in its favor. Second, I explore potential obstacles to the accommodation of these claims by the United States. The upshot is that – contrary to the assessment of the integrationists – it is quite easy to imagine American foreign policy failing to accommodate Chinese status claims.

The Rise of China and the Rights of a Great Power

In two respects, China's current foreign policy bears a striking resemblance to Japan's Shidehara diplomacy and Germany's Locarno diplomacy. First, it is concerned with avoiding provocation and working within the extant international order to improve China's position. Second, it is aimed at enhancing China's status in the world. That status anxiety is one of the most salient features of Chinese foreign policy is widely supported by recent scholarship. One observer suggests that “China's status sensitivity appears unparalleled.”¹⁴ International social status (*Guoji Diwei*) has been a prominent part of Chinese foreign policy discourse since the middle of the 1990s, and leaders often treat it “as if it were the most desirable value, the one that leads to power, security, and respect.”¹⁵

¹⁴ Deng (2008), p. 9; see also Wolf (2014), p. 207; and Xuetong (2001).

¹⁵ Deng (2008), p. 8.

And it is not just that leaders value status. A range of scholars notes that the Chinese public (at least the politically engaged portion of it) is watching and cares about China's standing.¹⁶ According to Chinese IR scholar Yan Xuetong (in 2001), "most Chinese people merely hope that their nation can grow to be as rich as the United States and can secure proper respect in the international community."¹⁷ Recent opinion surveys have shown that large numbers of politically active Chinese hope for at least "shared leadership" in the international system. According to one 2012 study, strong majorities of Chinese believe that the United States and important Asian allies like India, Vietnam, and Japan do not respect China and that "China is not receiving the due treatment it deserves on the international stage."¹⁸ Another used experimental methods to demonstrate that "perceived humiliation threat" is a more important driver of Chinese attitudes about policy toward the United States than "perceived military threat."¹⁹

The status that China is seeking is somewhat ambiguous, but seems to be a particular understanding of membership in a "legitimate" great power club in which members – including the United States – have equal standing. Status-seeking is implicated in a variety of concrete policies, including China's accession to international organizations, its drive to host the Olympics, its participation in UN peacekeeping missions, and its pursuit of a fleet of aircraft carriers.²⁰ While one might argue that China has already achieved great power status (in light of its permanent seat on the UN Security Council), Beijing does not agree. In July 2010, in response to a series of Sino-American crises in which US behavior violated what Chinese elites apparently understand as appropriate standards of great power interaction, the *People's Daily* – a mouthpiece for the Communist Party of China – asked: "Is the United States ready to recognize China as a power on the world stage?"²¹

As is the case whenever a state seeks status, satisfaction comes not primarily from achieving status markers but rather from recognition. It is clear that Chinese leaders and the Chinese public do not believe that their claims have been adequately recognized. What recognition of great power status means to China today is somewhat uncertain, in part because Chinese leaders have often seemed hesitant to openly discuss

¹⁶ Wolf (2014), pp. 207–209; Xuetong (2001); Shambaugh (2013), Chapters 2 and 3; Gries (2005a).

¹⁷ Xuetong (2001), p. 36. ¹⁸ Jung (2012), p. 14; see also Wolf (2014), fn. 74.

¹⁹ Gries et al. (2011), p. 17.

²⁰ Deng (2008), p. 35; see also Larson and Shevchenko (2010); Goldstein (2005); Zhang and Tang (2005). On the Beijing Olympics, see Xu (2006); on the *Varyag*, see Ross (2009) and Pu and Schweller (2014).

²¹ Zhong (2010).

specifics.²² However, understanding great power status as carrying with it a bundle of rights and privileges yields some insight. Recognizing China's claim to great power status today would require the United States and others to acknowledge China's heightened position by 1) behaving in ways that seem to grant that China can take actions that are appropriate and legitimate for great powers to take; and 2) not behaving in ways that communicate that China does not have the same rights as other great powers.²³

But what, exactly, are the rights that China claims? In 2012, then Vice President Xi Jinping introduced the concept of the "New Type of Great Power Relations" as a framework for reforming the Sino-American relationship.²⁴ This is the clearest indication yet that part of what China wants is recognition and respect, and provides important clues about the concrete rights that Beijing claims. According to one analyst, the point of the diplomatic effort is to convince "the American president to recognize that China is dramatically rising in military and economic ways," which will allow China to be "nicer" in a "very tense situation."²⁵ Cheng Li and Lucy Xu suggest that "China wants to be viewed as an equal. By using the term 'Great Power' to primarily, if not solely, refer to China and the United States, China aims to elevate itself to a level playing field."²⁶ Part of the reason for seeking recognition of equal status is domestic: "By strengthening China's view of itself as a recognized and respected power, Xi Jinping is able to foster stronger nationalistic pride under CCP leadership and gain political capital to consolidate his own power at home."²⁷

Respect as an equal and recognition as a great power seem to refer to two related rights: an acknowledged geographical sphere of influence, and a set of interests that other states agree not to threaten.²⁸ At the center of Xi's proposal is the idea that China and the United States should respect each other's "core interests." Read in combination with previous assertions of the nature of China's core interests, this means, in more concrete terms, that China is demanding that the United States recognize a Chinese sphere of influence in East Asia (likely including the South

²² Deng (2008), p. 13.

²³ On great power status as a bundle of rights and privileges, see Bull (1977), p. 196; Suzuki (2008), p. 47; Simpson (2004), pp. 68–71.

²⁴ See Lampton (2013) for a discussion. ²⁵ Perez (2013). ²⁶ Li and Xu (2014).

²⁷ Ibid.

²⁸ This is consistent with the English School's definition of "great power." For Bull (1977), two of the privileges that great powers have are 1) the "unilateral exercise of preponderance in particular areas of the world or among particular groups of states" (p. 207); and 2) the establishment of "spheres of influence, interest, or responsibility" (p. 212); see also Simpson (2004), pp. 70–71; and Heimann (2014).

China Sea), and make a commitment to respect China's sovereignty by dialing back the pressure on Chinese human rights abuses.²⁹

There are, of course, other reasons for Chinese leaders to harbor these ambitions. Their demands may not be entirely or even primarily *driven* by status concerns. What matters is that – whatever the primary motivation – these demands *engage* status concerns because of the way that Chinese elites understand and talk about them. The official Chinese line is that the “New Type of Great Power Relations” is not about power maximization, but rather about “the principle of treating each other as equals,” and constructing a relationship in which “neither side should see itself above the other side.”³⁰ This means that these specific issues may come to be seen in China as tests of Washington's willingness to recognize Chinese claims to equal status, in the same way that the British response to the Morocco crises of 1905 and 1911 or the Western response to the Mukden Incident were seen as tests of British and American willingness to recognize German and Japanese status claims. This, in turn, raises the possibility that a failure to accommodate Chinese claims could produce forces similar to those that operated in the twentieth-century revisionists.

Why the West Might Not Accommodate China

But the liberal international order, according to the integrationists, is uniquely suited to accommodating the rise of new great powers. The open, rule-based order provides opportunities for Chinese status and influence over the governance of the system to be increased without destabilizing the order itself. This is true, and it is also true that declining powers do not invariably oppose rising challengers.

Still, the West's ability and inclination to accommodate Chinese status claims are more uncertain than the integrationists let on. This is partly because – to the extent that great power status involves a right to a sphere of influence – Chinese claims are unlikely to be fully satisfied by, for instance, increasing China's vote share in the IMF. But it is also because of the overlapping obstacles that often prevent status accommodation. The prospects for status accommodation of China by the United States face four distinct kinds of obstacles.

First, status accommodation of the rising power might conflict with the security interests of the declining power. This is not always true – many

²⁹ Mancinelli (2014), p. 15. On the claim that part of what China is demanding (or is likely to demand in the future) is a sphere of influence in East Asia, see Tiezzi (2014); Kupchan (2012), p. 200; Schweller (2014), Kindle location 1459; and Friedberg (2015), p. 143. On Chinese sensitivity to human rights rhetoric, see Carlson (2005), p. 239.

³⁰ Tankai and Hanzhao (2012), Section III.

British leaders did not think accommodating American status claims conflicted with the British Empire's vital security interests; and the Western powers could have done much more than they did to accommodate Japanese status claims without undermining American or British security. But sometimes accommodating the rights associated with a status category is incompatible with the way the established power defines its vital security interests. During the late nineteenth and twentieth centuries, the possession of large navies consisting of battleships was a marker of the status category "world power."³¹ As Chapter 3 showed, while Germany's *Flottenpolitik* was primarily motivated by status and identity concerns, it threatened British security, which required naval superiority. The incompatibility of Germany's status claim with British security made it difficult if not impossible for the British to accede to German demands for recognition of the right to naval parity.

Are Chinese status claims likely to conflict with vital American security interests? This depends on what one thinks American interests are. If it is true that China's claim to great power status depends in part on acquiring a recognized sphere of influence in East Asia (a sort of Chinese Monroe Doctrine encompassing the South China Sea), then future American leaders will face a difficult choice: either accommodate Chinese claims by recognizing China's special role in East Asia, or commit to maintaining American dominance in East Asia at the risk of signaling status denial. I return to the implications of this dilemma for American grand strategy in the next chapter; for now it is enough to note that it is not clear that any American leader would be able to square China's claim to privilege in the South China Sea with the vital security interests of the United States, as they are currently understood – indeed even those who counsel accommodation of China do not go so far as to propose that the United States abandon its dominant role in East Asia.³²

Second, the rising power's status claims might be incompatible with the established or declining power's understanding of its identity. This might be the case if the established power's dominant identity narrative depends upon a claim to superiority or to exceptionalism. Under these conditions, it might be difficult for a leader in the established power to sustainably acknowledge that another state belonged in the same status category or had access to equal rights. For instance, during the fifteenth, sixteenth, and seventeenth centuries, China refused to recognize first Japanese and then British claims to equal rights and status. Leaders in Edo and London

³¹ Murray (2010); Steinberg (1965).

³² Ikenberry (2011), p. 356; Kupchan (2012), p. 201. One important exception is Layne (2014).

were uncomfortable playing by the rules of the Sino-Centric order, which involved tribute and kowtowing to signal Chinese dominance and foreign submission.³³ Bending these rules was unthinkable to Ming and Qing leaders because China's identity narrative involved an exceptionalist claim to the divine origin and sanction of the emperor. Accommodating Japanese and British requests for immunity from the performance of the rituals that constituted Chinese dominance would have threatened not only China's status but also its self-understanding. According to Ringmar (writing about the Chinese refusal to recognize Great Britain's demand for formal equality): "the model that had placed the Chinese sun at its symbolic center could not easily be traded for a model in which China was merely one billiard ball among others following an independent path."³⁴

There is good reason to be concerned that identity politics could hamper Sino-American accommodation. One problem is that American political discourse includes prominent claims to exceptionalism and indispensability. Even the Obama administration – which acknowledged a preference for "leading from behind" and was criticized from the right for abandoning exceptionalism – maintained a commitment to the United States' unique role in the world. The 2015 National Security Strategy reasserted a belief in an "American exceptionalism" rooted in "founding values," and argued that "there are no global problems that can be solved without the United States."³⁵ Exceptionalist identity narratives fit awkwardly with claims to equal rights by others. When Chinese leaders and the Chinese public wonder why the United States can exercise unilateral power abroad or maintain a sphere of influence in its periphery while acting and talking as if China does not have the same rights, responding that American founding values make the United States a unique force for good is unlikely to satisfy. A related problem is that to be an American leader is to support a range of values that are inconsistent with Chinese status claims. American official support, for instance, for human rights and liberal democracy violate Chinese understandings of what it means to respect sovereignty, let alone what it means to act appropriately toward another great power.³⁶

The third obstacle is rooted in the domestic politics of the established power. Leaders in dominant states are sometimes constrained from taking steps to signal recognition of rising state status claims by concerns

³³ On the Sino-Centric order, see Fairbank (1968), Jansen (2000), Toby (1984), and Kang (2010).

³⁴ Ringmar (2012), p. 17. ³⁵ The White House (2015), pp. 2–3.

³⁶ See Deng (2008), Chapter 3 on this point. The 2015 National Security Strategy (The White House 2015, p. 19) makes clear that the United States is committed to "promoting universal values abroad."

about the reaction of important domestic groups. In certain types of domestic regimes, leaders might also be unable to prevent sub-state actors from taking steps that communicate status denial. The discussion of Japan's struggle for recognition in Chapter 4 provides several examples illustrating these dynamics. Australian Prime Minister Billy Hughes opposed the racial equality clause at the Paris Peace Conference in part because he knew that opposition was a political winner. Similarly, one of the reasons Woodrow Wilson ultimately opposed the clause was because of its political implications for domestic race relations. Indeed, the broader conflict between the West and Japan over immigration, which played such an important role in the story of failed accommodation, was driven largely by domestic politics, and in some cases even by local politics.³⁷

American domestic politics could certainly pose an obstacle to accommodation of Chinese status claims. This goes beyond a general unwillingness to appear weak or to renegotiate international commitments out of a concern about the reaction of domestic audiences. There is also, according to many observers, a tradition of "China-bashing" during US election seasons.³⁸ As Ted Galen Carpenter notes, during campaigns "the major party candidates vie to see who can appear tougher on China" in what is "a quadrennial political ritual."³⁹ The rise of Chinese economic power coupled with American economic difficulties have combined recently to make China an even more attractive target for scapegoating. Chinese citizens have noticed, which has perhaps contributed to a recent decline in Chinese attitudes toward the United States.⁴⁰ In short, the pressures of domestic politics could make it difficult for leaders in the White House or Congress to support accommodation.

The fourth obstacle is alliance politics. Leaders are sometimes constrained from pursuing accommodation because they are concerned about the reactions of their allies. During the Paris Peace Conference, for instance, the primary reason that British leaders opposed the racial equality clause was that they knew the Dominion governments (especially the Australians) were against it. Similarly, while American and British

³⁷ For an overview, see Shimazu (1998).

³⁸ On China-bashing in 2012, see Oded Shenkar (2012); Madison Park (2012); Brower and Lerer (2012); Osnos (2012); Washington Post Editorial Board (2012).

³⁹ Carpenter (2012). This was even more evident during the 2016 election cycle, which saw Donald Trump accuse China of "raping" the American economy. Trump has also famously declared that climate change was a "hoax" concocted by Beijing to "make U.S. manufacturing non-competitive," though he did so via Twitter in 2012. See Diamond (May 2, 2016) and Wong (November 18, 2016).

⁴⁰ Park (2012); "Why China-Bashing Dominates U.S. Presidential Elections," People's Daily Online (2012).

leaders preferred a conciliatory settlement after World War I and tried at times after Versailles to accommodate German claims, they were constrained by French opposition.⁴¹

Alliance politics could also trouble Sino-American relations. Even if future American leaders decide to acknowledge, in some form, a Chinese sphere of influence in East Asia, they might still care about maintaining security relationships with countries like Japan and South Korea, since these arguably have benefits that go beyond containing China.⁴² But this could prove impossible, since erstwhile East Asian allies might begin to doubt the credibility of American security guarantees. They are already nervous: in the face of a Chinese push to assert territorial claims in the South China Sea, American foreign policy has in recent years been oriented toward reassuring allies that the United States is committed to East Asia. Predictably, this has worsened Sino-American relations.⁴³ The upshot is that it is unclear whether accommodation of Chinese status claims and the maintenance of American alliance commitments in East Asia are compatible objectives.

None of this is to say that accommodation is *impossible*. But it is likely to be much more difficult than the integrationists – who focus primarily on the openness of the institutions of the liberal order – suggest. Effective accommodation would likely require the United States to make serious sacrifices not just in terms of giving up influence in international institutions, but also in terms of dramatically redefining the way it conceives of its role abroad. Accommodation may not ultimately be in the United States' best interest. But that is a conclusion that cannot be drawn without first considering the potential consequences of status denial, which is the question that occupies the rest of this chapter.

Status Immobility and Chinese Foreign Policy

There is not yet widespread support in China for policies aimed at rejecting the liberal international order. One 2012 opinion survey suggested that only fifteen percent of Chinese advocate creating a “new, alternative China-led world order and institutions,” and, on the whole, the Chinese public remains optimistic about China's trajectory.⁴⁴

Yet there are reasons to worry that the ground is fertile for the development and spread of beliefs that China faces a status “glass ceiling.” One

⁴¹ See Tooze (2014) for an overview of interwar haggling between the Allies.

⁴² Brooks, Ikenberry, and Wohlforth (2013), pp. 40–50.

⁴³ On American reassurance and its consequences for Sino-American relations, see Ott (2014); Denyer (2014); and Ross (2012).

⁴⁴ Jung (2012), pp. 10–13.

is that China – like Imperial Japan – has a legacy of being humiliated by Western powers. This has resulted in a “victim mentality” that could make claims that great power status is unavailable particularly resonant.⁴⁵ According to Deng (who argues that China is the most status conscious country in the world), the “century of humiliation” that lasted from the Opium Wars to the end of World War II may explain China’s status sensitivity; Yan Xuetong suggests that “the Chinese regard their rise as regaining China’s lost international status rather than obtaining something new”; William Callahan argues that an important objective of Chinese foreign policy is to “cleanse National Humiliation,” and that invocations of shame and humiliation at the hands of the West have played a central role in the development of Chinese nationalism; Christopher Hughes, similarly, claims that the Chinese Communist Party routinely promises to “deliver the nation from humiliation” as a way of legitimating its rule.⁴⁶ While leaders have so far used appeals to national humiliation instrumentally to mobilize and consolidate support for limited revisionist policies, the analysis throughout this book shows that this kind of sentiment can take on a life of its own. In combination with foreign behavior that seems to deny status claims, it might contribute to the emergence of political conditions that interfere with efforts to pursue moderate policies.⁴⁷

A second reason to worry about the development of status immobility in China is the inherent tension between China’s domestic political institutions and the way that Western leaders seem to understand the requirements for entry into the “responsible” great power club. In particular, Chinese leaders are wary of the fact that a commitment to democracy and respect for Western conceptions of human rights may be central markers of status in the contemporary international system.⁴⁸ One important objective of Chinese foreign policy has been to reduce the extent to which relevant others view China as disqualified from legitimate great power status on these grounds. It has done so in two ways: by improving perceptions of China’s human rights record, and by altering the “standard of great power recognition” through an effort to change or

⁴⁵ For an analysis of the temporal component of Chinese status dissatisfaction, see Freedman (2016).

⁴⁶ Deng (2008), p. 41; Yan Xuetong (2001), p. 34; Callahan (2004), p. 205; Hughes (2006), p. 156; see also Li (2009), p. 183.

⁴⁷ See Wang (2008), p. 802; Gries et al. (2005b), p. 17; and Barne (1995), for analyses of these dynamics.

⁴⁸ See especially Deng (2008), Chapter 3; on democracy as a marker of status in the contemporary system, see Kim (2003); on human rights norms as markers of legitimacy or status, see Sikkink (1993); Risse and Sikkink (1999); Donnelly (1998); Clark (2005); and Krasner (1995).

reduce the salience of respect for human rights as a marker.⁴⁹ Deng notes that Chinese “compliance” behaviors – including accession to a series of human rights treaties – are attempts to enhance China’s status through integration and emulation. At the same time, China has tried to “minimize human rights as a yardstick for international standing” by emphasizing the value of sovereignty and the cultural relativity of human rights standards.⁵⁰

Chinese status sensitivity might seem to provide leverage for Western states to influence China’s domestic institutions and behavior by holding out recognition of great power status as a carrot. But this could be dangerous. The more stridently Western leaders insist that China must “accept and contribute to the evolving international legal regime on issues such as human rights, [and] collective defense of democracy,” the more convinced Chinese leaders and elites may become that it is impossible to achieve recognition of great power status without fundamentally undermining the regime.⁵¹ In fact, some Chinese elites already seem to think that the Western focus on democracy promotion and human rights is a deliberate plot to prevent China’s rise to great power status.⁵²

A third reason to worry about status immobility in China is racial difference. While American foreign policy is not explicitly organized around racial distinctions like it was a century ago, Chinese observers could easily interpret slights by the United States and its leaders in racial terms. William Callahan has recently argued that contemporary Chinese conceptions of race bear a striking similarity to those of the nineteenth-century West. “In its racial nationalist form,” he writes, “Chinese identity is part of a hierarchy, with Han Chinese at the top and blacks at the bottom.”⁵³ The meaning of the term *Minzu* (which Chinese frequently use to refer to China) “is quite broad and ambiguous, ranging from ethnicity to nation to race.”⁵⁴ This does not mean that Chinese view the world exclusively through the lens of race or think of international politics as a competition between racial groups. But racial interpretations remain prominently available to Chinese trying to make sense of international politics – as they were for Japanese in the 1920s and 1930s. This could be problematic for reasons explored in Chapter 4: an apparent racial

⁴⁹ Deng (2008), p. 89. ⁵⁰ *Ibid.*, pp. 82–92.

⁵¹ Castañeda (2011); Clunan (2014b), p. 295, makes a similar point about the dangers of forcing aspiring powers to conform to Western status criteria.

⁵² See Bernstein (2012); and Lieberthal and Wang (2012). In his contribution to the coauthored report cited in this note, Wang (p. 12) even claims that “it is widely believed in the Chinese leadership that the Americans orchestrated awarding the Nobel Peace Prize to Liu Xiaobo in October 2010.”

⁵³ Callahan (2013), p. 104. ⁵⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 104.

obstacle could dampen Chinese optimism about the prospects of satisfying their international status ambitions.⁵⁵

But even if a strong belief that China faces a status “glass ceiling” does develop, would it have an effect on Chinese foreign policy? In the remainder of this section, I argue that it is not difficult to imagine status immobility unleashing in China similar social psychological and political forces as it did in Wilhelmine Germany, Imperial Japan, and Weimar Germany.

Chinese Status Anxiety and Demands for Rejection

The foreign policy preferences of China’s elite vary fairly widely. Shambaugh and Xiao have identified seven distinct orientations toward the status quo within Chinese foreign policy discourse. At the integrationist end of the spectrum are the Globalists, who believe that China should take on additional responsibility for global governance within the existing framework of institutions – in short, China should “act as a responsible power.”⁵⁶ Chinese Globalists are much like Western “liberal institutionalists,” and are thus generally supportive of the liberal order. Five other perspectives (which Shambaugh and Xiao identify as Selective Multilateralists, the Global South school, the Asia Firsters, the Major Powers School, and the Realists) are less sold on the liberal order, but at least agree that some degree of participation in its institutions, norms, and rules is necessary.⁵⁷

But there is one group – the Nativists – that rejects participation in the liberal international order. The Nativists are “hyper-nationalist” Marxist ideologues who oppose domestic reforms aimed at producing openness and market capitalism. In the realm of foreign policy, they oppose participation in the liberal order because they “view international multilateral involvement as ‘traps’ (laid by the West) to embroil China in costly overseas commitments.”⁵⁸ Nativists have multiple reasons for rejecting integration, not all of which have to do with status – for instance, they worry that participation in the Western order will destabilize the Communist Party. But they are also deeply concerned about China’s status and are skeptical about the prospects of achieving their ambitions within an order dominated by Western powers. According to Shambaugh and Xiao, Nativists “regularly harp on the nationalist theme of the ‘century of shame and

⁵⁵ Christensen, Johnston, and Ross (2006), p. 411, agree that the role of “racial stereotypes in the formulation and execution of foreign policy” – especially in China – is understudied but critical. See also Johnston’s reply in Chen, Pu, and Johnston (2014).

⁵⁶ Shambaugh and Xiao (2012), Kindle location 1238. ⁵⁷ Ibid., Kindle location 1265.

⁵⁸ Ibid., Kindle location 1025.

humiliation' and argue that China is entitled to global respect (particularly by those powers that previously humiliated China)."⁵⁹

Liu Mingfu's sensationally popular *China Dream* is a remarkably open call for a deep revisionist challenge to the liberal order. While Liu may not be a Nativist (according to Shambaugh's classification), his writing is worth considering as a modern Chinese manifestation of the kind of argument that Friedrich von Bernhardi popularized in Germany during the years before World War I. Liu's central proposition is that China should aim to become a "champion" nation – the global top dog or leader (as distinct from the hegemon, which to Liu implies a form of imperialism and military domination). As the "champion," China would "create a new world order that prefers peace, development, freedom, and cooperative civilization." This seems like a clear demand for China to – at some point – remake the international order.

What is significant is the source of the demand for radical revisionism, and its implications for China's participation in the liberal order. Liu links the need for a new order to the deficiencies of American hegemony, the "worst expression" of which is "its monopolization of its status as champion."⁶⁰ In other words, the United States will not accede willingly to China's attainment of a position of equality in a "multipolar" world. The book goes on to document and decry American efforts to contain the rise of China, considers lessons from the successful American defeat of two other potential "champions" (the Soviet Union and Japan), and makes a clear argument against integrating too deeply within the liberal order:

However, it cannot be denied that America has a clear upper hand in terms of control and power with China. China can be promoted to copilot to help the United States cope with risks, but this will only help America maintain its position as pilot. America allows opponents to board its plane, which is ultimately a higher degree of control and containment.⁶¹

Integrating within the liberal order would amount to becoming Washington's "copilot," which would do nothing more than strengthen the basis of a status hierarchy that the United States is intent upon preserving. This is reminiscent of the way that Bernhardi, militant pan-Asianists, and Weimar nationalists argued against participation in the pre-World War I and interwar orders. And Liu's book is hardly peripheral: in 2013, Xi Jinping began invoking the term "China Dream" to describe his vision for

⁵⁹ Ibid., Kindle location 1053. See also Shambaugh (2013), pp. 27–31. Other authors have also identified a deeply revisionist strand of Chinese foreign policy thought. Callahan (2013), p. 43, calls it "divergence"; and Schweller and Pu (2011), p. 61, identify a group who advocates that China construct a "new Chinese world order."

⁶⁰ Liu (2015), Kindle location 953. ⁶¹ Ibid., Kindle location 3890.

China's future, and has reportedly been deeply influenced by the book's central argument.⁶²

Nativists and other revisionists may not be ascendant in Chinese foreign policy decisionmaking, but their foreign policy preferences are not marginal either. While other schools of thought do not take such strident positions against participation in the liberal order, some share a sense of skepticism: Realists for instance, are also concerned that Western institutions are traps meant to keep China down.⁶³ And Chinese elites remain worried about Chinese status and link it to the terms of participation in the liberal order – they emphasize “equality of participation” over “governance” and chafe at the idea of complying with American standards in order to be recognized as a “responsible power.”⁶⁴

So while Chinese foreign policy is currently run mostly by proponents of intermediate and at least partially integrationist perspectives, Nativists and others like Liu constitute a loud and potentially influential voice for policies that reject the liberal international order – much like Pan-Asians or German radical nationalists spent the 1920s demanding policies of protest and delegitimation from the more moderate leaders who ran Taishō and Weimar foreign policy.⁶⁵ It is not difficult to imagine support for the Nativist perspective (not just among the elite but also in the public) growing along with developments that seem to confirm fears that Chinese status ambitions face an insurmountable, unjust obstacle imposed by the United States and the liberal order. Indeed, evidence suggests that Chinese “netizen” nationalists are hyper-aware of status issues and often mobilize in response to concerns about the way China is treated by foreign actors and what that treatment says about China's international standing.⁶⁶

Status, Domestic Politics, and Chinese Foreign Policy

The question that remains is whether – in China's authoritarian system – pressure from outside the government for radical revisionist policies could have much influence. The government is (and likely will be for the foreseeable future) committed to foreign policy moderation: but what if developments appearing to confirm that China faces a status “glass ceiling” increase support for the Nativist position and lead to widespread demands for policies aimed at rejecting the liberal order? Could these forces impact Chinese policy in the same way that they impacted German

⁶² Page (2013). ⁶³ Shambaugh and Xiao (2012), Kindle location 1116.

⁶⁴ Ibid., Kindle location 1274.

⁶⁵ Pillsbury (2015) argues that Chinese foreign policy is *already* fundamentally oriented toward overthrowing the liberal order.

⁶⁶ Shen and Breslin (2010), p. 265.

and Japanese policy? It is hard to know for sure, but there is good reason to think that the government is susceptible to influence from external pressure and that it may only become more so in the future.

While some scholars maintain that Chinese policymakers mostly effectively ignore public opinion, or that public opinion prompts short-term shifts in official rhetoric or policy but does not influence grand strategic direction, many others agree that “bottom-up” forces play a significant role in Chinese foreign policy.⁶⁷ Unofficial attitudes and preferences cannot influence policy through the mechanisms of electoral political competition, but this does not mean they are irrelevant. First, policy has to be at least somewhat responsive to the diversity of elite preferences – just as Bethmann Hollweg was constrained by the attitudes of the Kaiser, Tirpitz, and the Pan-Germans, Chinese leaders may be constrained by the preferences of Nativists and some status-sensitive and integration-skeptical Realists in the military and the Party.⁶⁸ Second, mass opinion can threaten China’s elite through the dynamics of widespread popular protest. According to Weiss, mass protests may menace ruling elites by creating demonstration effects, tipping points, and information cascades; facilitating future mobilization against the regime; and fostering or exacerbating divisions within the leadership.⁶⁹ And while strong authoritarian states like China can prevent and manage anti-regime protests, there are costs and risks associated with doing so, especially when public opinion is aimed at forcing the regime to adopt a more aggressive foreign policy posture.⁷⁰ This means that the masses can be a potent weapon for anyone interested in forcing the government into adopting a more belligerent foreign policy; in turn, this means that any factor that makes it easier to mobilize anti-Western opinion (such as apparent evidence that the United States is unwilling to accommodate a Chinese claim to equal rights) may provide opportunities for Chinese proponents of challenging the liberal order.

This logic is supported by scholars of Chinese foreign policy who contend that public pressure has influenced policy in the past and will continue to do so. These analysts point to a series of episodes – including, among others, the 1985 Sino-Japanese dispute over Prime Minister Nakasone’s visit to Yasukuni Shrine, the 2001 EP3 crisis, the 2003 decision to remove a contract to build a Chinese bullet train from the operator of Japan’s Shinkansen, the 2005 crisis over Japan’s attempt to win a permanent seat on the UN Security Council, and the 2012 Sino-Japanese Diaoyu-Senkaku

⁶⁷ For skeptical voices, see Shen (2004) and Reilly (2012), p. 5.

⁶⁸ Shambaugh and Xiao (2012), Kindle location 1302.

⁶⁹ Weiss (2014), p. 19; see also Weiss (2013). ⁷⁰ Weiss (2014), p. 19.

crisis – during which China's official policy became more aggressive in response to popular, nationalist pressure.⁷¹

There is nothing necessarily belligerent about Chinese public opinion, and not all scholars agree that it poses a challenge to the maintenance of moderate foreign policy.⁷² But under the wrong circumstances, the role of the Chinese public could make it difficult for moderate leaders to avoid taking provocative steps that they might prefer not to. For instance, in the wake of a major crisis with the United States over the status of the South China Sea, nationalist popular opinion would be ripe for exploitation by hardline elites.⁷³ The result would likely be intense pressure on Chinese moderates to move away from integration within the liberal order – which, after all, is seen by Nativists and many Realists as nothing more than a tool to perpetuate the dominance of the United States by containing China. A crisis that seemed to validate this view would produce political resources for the proponents of a wide range of provocative policies.

And the role of the Chinese public is only likely to become more important in the future. The slow and uneven opening up of China's political system – a result of hesitant local-level democratization, increasingly influential media, and, most important, the growth of the internet as a site for political contestation – raises the possibility that China's elite may come under even more serious pressure from below.⁷⁴ Netizenship, in particular, has drawn a great deal of attention from China-watchers as a potential threat to the regime. Chinese online forums facilitate the publication and distribution of news and opinion, as well as popular mobilization.⁷⁵ Xin-An Lu attributes recently inflamed anti-Japan and anti-US public pressure in part to the internet; and while the Chinese regime has tools at its disposal to control online nationalist opinions, there are costs associated with using them.⁷⁶

The upshot is that the regime may become more vulnerable to external pressure over the next several years.⁷⁷ This has a wide range of implications

⁷¹ See Reilly (2012), pp. 69–70; Li (2005), p. 59; Hong (2005), p. 102; Weiss (2014), Chapters 6 and 8; and for a summary of a handful of other crises, see Lu (2005), pp. 114–116.

⁷² See, for example, Lai (2010).

⁷³ On elite conflict and popular protest in China, see Fewsmith and Rosen (2001), pp. 172–175.

⁷⁴ See Wang (2006); Yu (2005); and on the internet see Junhao Hong (2005); Lu (2005); Shen and Breslin (2010); Lu (2009); John Lagerkvist (2010); Tai (2006); Qiang (2011); Shirk (2011); Hao and Hou (2009); Yu (2009); Wu (2007). For dissenting opinions about the influence of netizenship on Chinese politics, see MacKinnon (2008), and Feldman (2013).

⁷⁵ Hong (2005), p. 95. ⁷⁶ Lu (2005), p. 114; Shen and Breslin (2010), p. 275.

⁷⁷ Indeed, Shambaugh (2015) has recently suggested that the collapse of the Communist Party is imminent.

for the future of the liberal international order, one of which is that the social psychological and political forces that status immobility unleashed in Germany and Japan during the first half of the twentieth century could well operate in contemporary China as well.

Conclusion

There are, of course, also reasons for optimism. Younger members of the elite have more favorable attitudes toward the United States than do older generations; there are powerful Chinese groups (especially in coastal provinces) deeply invested in continued integration with the international economy and caution in foreign policy. According to Hongyi Lai, China's "primary domestic imperatives suggest that peaceful rise and prevention of a major war are in [its] best interests."⁷⁸ And, most importantly, Beijing continues to value caution and stability in foreign policy and still seems capable of managing nationalist frustrations without allowing them to dictate its course.⁷⁹ In short, the integrationists may be right.

Still, analysts and policymakers should not ignore Chinese status anxiety. Taking status seriously suggests that the integrationist and rejectionist perspectives are both inaccurate. Rejectionists ignore the dynamics of status immobility which blinds them to the possibility that the policy they promote could create the revisionist China whose development they think inevitable. Another way to put this is that rejectionists ignore the full costs of containment – these include not just the material and opportunity costs of military spending and the potential for security dilemma dynamics, but also the possibility of creating and empowering elites with preferences deeply opposed to the liberal international order.

Integrationists, on the other hand, underestimate the difficulty of successful accommodation. Recognizing China's status claims may require the United States to dramatically redefine the way it understands the role it plays in the world. The purpose of pointing this out is not to advocate accommodation, but to suggest that perhaps China cannot be bought off by increasing its influence in the institutions of the

⁷⁸ Lai (2010), p. 169; see also Lieberthal and Wang (2012); Hao and Su (2005), p. 30; and Chen (2005).

⁷⁹ For instance, Beijing's response to the recent Permanent Court of Arbitration rejection of its South China Sea claims has been encouragingly restrained, though the ruling prompted expressions of fury and resentment (including a call to prepare for a "people's war at sea") probably intended to signal resolve and satisfy nationalist demands for protest. See Wuthnow (2016).

liberal international order or even by facilitating the return of Taiwan to Beijing's control. Satisfying China's status claims may be much more painful than that. Whether doing so is ultimately worth it is an important debate – and one that requires a clear understanding of the potential costs of both accommodation and denial.